is nothing more toxic to a leader than to become the object of satire. It strips them of some of their mystique." He does caution, though, against the CJP becoming a political party prematurely. As he says, "One of the sources of support for the CJP is the fact that it is non-political and not seen as an offshoot of either the Congress, the BJP or AAP. If it becomes a political party, then its effectiveness will get enormously diluted." However, though there is merit in Jairam's argument, if the CJP does not become a political force, it runs the risk of being reduced to a glorified NGO.

Expanding the CJP Agenda

The CJP, then, must strike a careful balance between expanding its political influence without getting branded as an opportunistic outfit seeking power. For Dipke, the Jantar Mantar agitation clearly exposed the issues that bother Gen Z. "There is anger about the quality of education and its affordability," he says. "But the issue of unemployment loomed large too. The crowd was not made up of students alone but also included those in the 25-35 age group. Many protesters had degrees, but no jobs." What the CJP seems to have stumbled upon are grievances that have enormous resonance: the collision between rising youth aspirations and shrinking opportunities.

THE CJP HAS STUMBLED UPON ISSUES WITH POTENTIALLY MASSIVE REACH: RISING ASPIRATIONS COLLIDING WITH SHRINKING JOBS

Ashwani Kumar, political scientist and senior visiting fellow at the Centre for Policy Research in Delhi, sees an additional generational shift. Earlier aspirations followed a familiar vocabulary—doctor, engineer, journalist, civil servant—jobs that promised stability, status and upward mobility. Millennials and Gen Z, he argues, have changed that script. "The boundary between a job, gig, side hustle and a career has blurred. They want to design life on their own terms, but there are no opportunities for them."

Experts believe that the scale of this phenomenon could be considerably larger than the youth discontent that fed earlier movements. According to Professor Thomas Blom Hansen, a reputed political anthropologist at Stanford University who has studied nationalist and religious movements in India, "There is an accumulation of huge amounts of youth ambition and impatience with a system that doesn't seem to, in any way, yield or give them anything. It is potentially the most explosive issue in India at this moment: what's going to happen to all these young people who have very few opportunities going forward."

What they think about the CJP



"'School Thik Karo' is a useful campaign, but a programme has to be linked with policies. It's not whether the CJP can get a toilet repaired, but if it can articulate what a public education system should achieve"

— GHANSHYAM SHAH, *Political sociologist*



"A successful movement need not produce a successful party. CJP will be confronting a formidable BJP. It may be better off starting small rather than imagining itself as a national alternative"

— SANJAY KUMAR, *Professor, Centre for the Study of Developing Societies*

The challenge for the CJP is to convert that diffused frustration into demands broad enough to unite different constituencies but specific enough for a campaign to be built around them. At the first 'Cockroach Conclave' at Dipke's home in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar in Maharashtra on August 5, it was evident that the CJP was expanding its agenda from ensuring fair entrance examinations to better-quality government schools and affordable education, and from unemployment to recruitment irregularities and social security for gig workers. Its 'Kya Bolti Public?' exercise seeks to identify further grievances from below.

The danger, however, is that merely collecting grievances through its public outreach could produce an unwieldy shopping list. Political sociologist Ghanshyam Shah, who has studied Indian social movements since the 1970s, points out that while 'School Thik Karo' is a useful campaign, "programmes have to be linked with policies". For Shah, the larger question is not whether the CJP can get a broken toilet repaired, but whether it can articulate a compelling vision of what a public education system should achieve.

Economist Neeraj Hatekar agrees with Shah. "Increasing education budgets, filling teacher vacancies or changing curricula requires decisions at the top, and unless the CJP acquires political coverage, it will amount to just a repair job,"